Authoring a Virtual Patient

How an author builds a VP activity in VP Studio

Literal text
shown as written

Generated text
the LLM writes it

Interaction
the agent converses

From idea to student link

The author's path through VP Studio's simple-mode editor

1

New case

Start from scratch (Welcome + Final feedback), from a script template, or import a .vp.json file.

2

Shape the Activity Script

Add, move, rename and remove steps. The editor disables options that would break the script rules.

3

Fill each phase

Build the phase's pipeline of elements: Literal text, Generated text and Interaction.

4

Guide the agents

Attach hidden side information and strategies, insert {{fields}}, and tune the agent prompts.

5

Preview and try

Preview shows what the student sees. Try it plays the draft, with trace notes only the author sees.

6

Publish and share

Publish checks readiness and freezes a copy. Students play it at /vp/play/<case id>/.

The Activity Script

In the editor, the script is the list of steps; each step after Welcome is a phase



`order`
Steps run top to bottom, numbered from 0

`type`
Sets the phase banner and the answer field

`title`
The phase name; click it to rename the step

`summary`
The step's first text, shown while collapsed

`Add step here`
Offers only the steps the script rules allow

`fixed ends`
Welcome always first, Final feedback always last

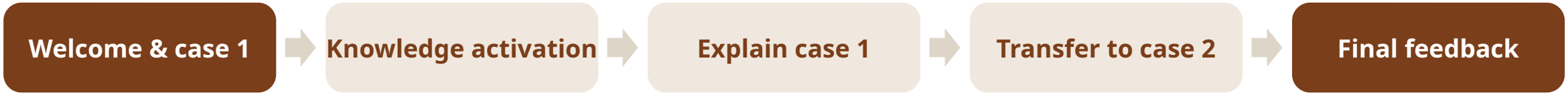
`Ready`
Or Needs input: what publishing still needs

`open`
Opens the step's pipeline of elements

`step options`
Move, rename or remove the step

Step types and their rules

Each type has a phase name, an answer field later steps can use, and a sequencing rule



Fixed ends: Welcome first, Final feedback last. **Middle:** pick the steps, e.g. the Recall → Explain → Transfer script above.

Step type	Phase banner	Answer field	Rule
`welcome`	(none)	`{{welcome.answer}}`	Exactly one, first
`know`	Knowledge Activation	`{{knowledge.answer}}`	At most once
`explain`	Narrative Construction	`{{case1.answer}}`	At most once
`assess`	Assessment	`{{assessment.answer}}`	After explain
`transfer`	Reasoning Transfer	`{{caseN.answer}}`	After explain; N = 2, 3, …
`interview`	Patient Interview	`{{interview.answer}}`	At most once
`reflect`	Reflection	`{{reflection.answer}}`	Once
`custom`	Its own title	`{{<key>.answer}}`	Unique answer key
`final`	(none)	`(none)`	Exactly one, last

The case also holds

`title`
The activity's name

`settings`
Student level (4 / 3 / 2 hints per point), progress bar

`agentPrompts`
Tutor persona, patient persona, guardrails

`strategyPrompts`
One instruction per strategy used

Structure of a phase

A step opens into its pipeline: elements that run top to bottom, then the answer it records

position
Phase 2 of the script

1 · Generated text
The tutor writes the phase introduction

2 · Literal text
The opening question; the student answers it first

3 · Interaction
The case discussion with the tutor

Add element
Append a Literal text, Generated text or Interaction



title
Phase name in the student's banner: Narrative Construction unless renamed

sideInfo
Hidden from the student: here the expert explanation the evaluator uses

answer
Recorded as {{case1.answer}}: that reply, or the last message of the interaction

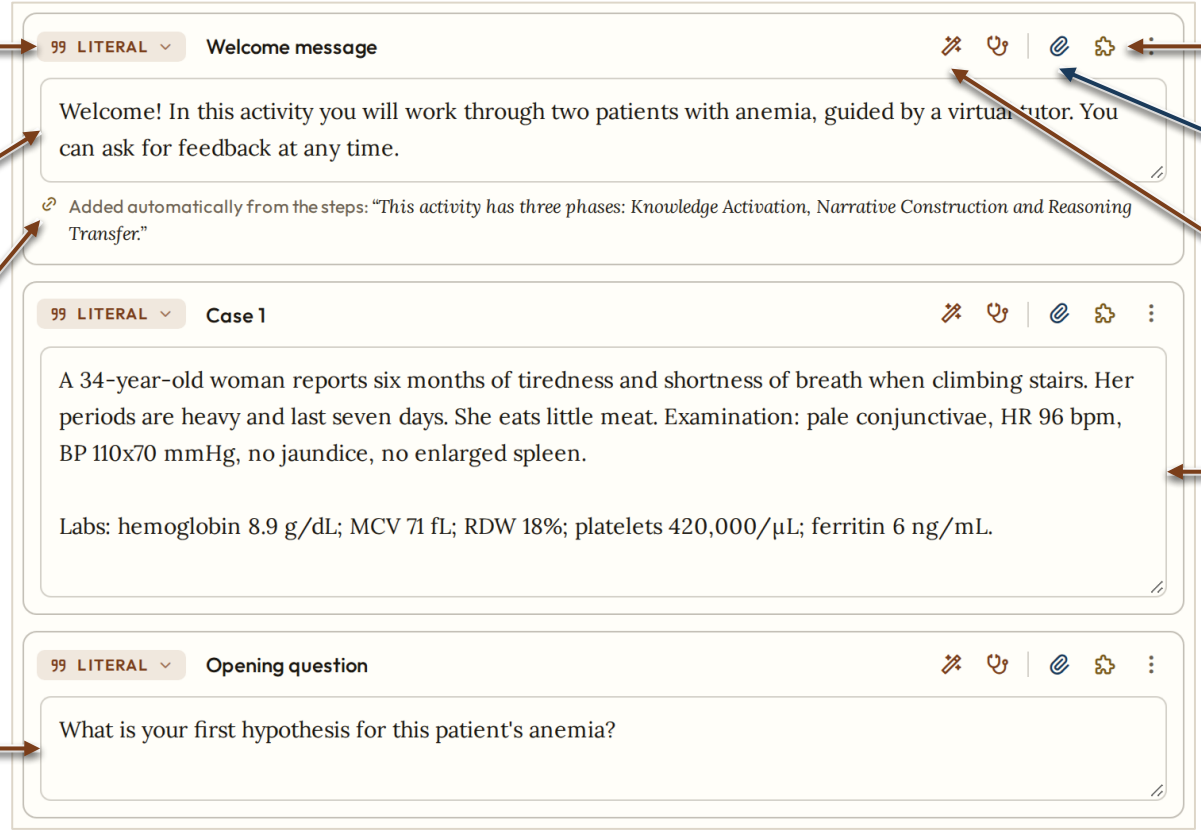
Literal text

Shown to the student exactly as the author wrote it

`kind · label`
The type (click to change) and the name the author sees

`text`
Exactly what the student reads; no {{fields}}

`autoPhaseSentence`
Welcome: the list of phases is appended



`opening question`
No card, just before an interaction: the student answers first

`strategies`
Gamification only

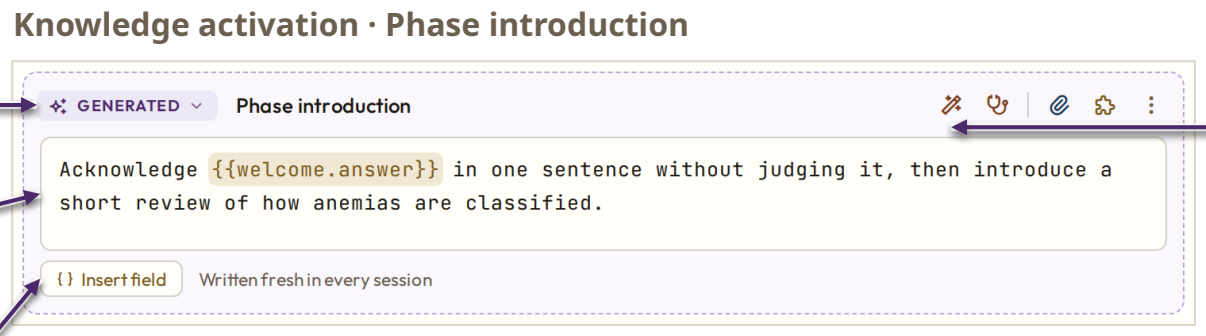
`sideInfo`
Attach hidden information

`assistant`
Writes the text, or a case vignette

`card · ref`
Case vignette: shown as a case card, usable as {{case1.vignette}}

Generated text

The author writes a prompt; the tutor writes the text when the session runs



`kind`
generated

`text`
A prompt to the tutor, in the second person, not what the student reads

`Insert field`
Lists what this step can use

`isFinalFeedback`
Final step: feedback from {{transcript}} and {{evaluator.log}}

`strategy`
Final feedback or Gamification

`assistant`
Drafts the prompt, or one that writes a vignette

`strategies`
One attached: 1

`{{fields}}`
Amber when known; red when unknown or not yet available

`moment`
on start · per turn · at end; click to change

Also in the document: **`ref`** makes the generated text a field for later steps.

Interaction

A multi-turn conversation between the student and an agent

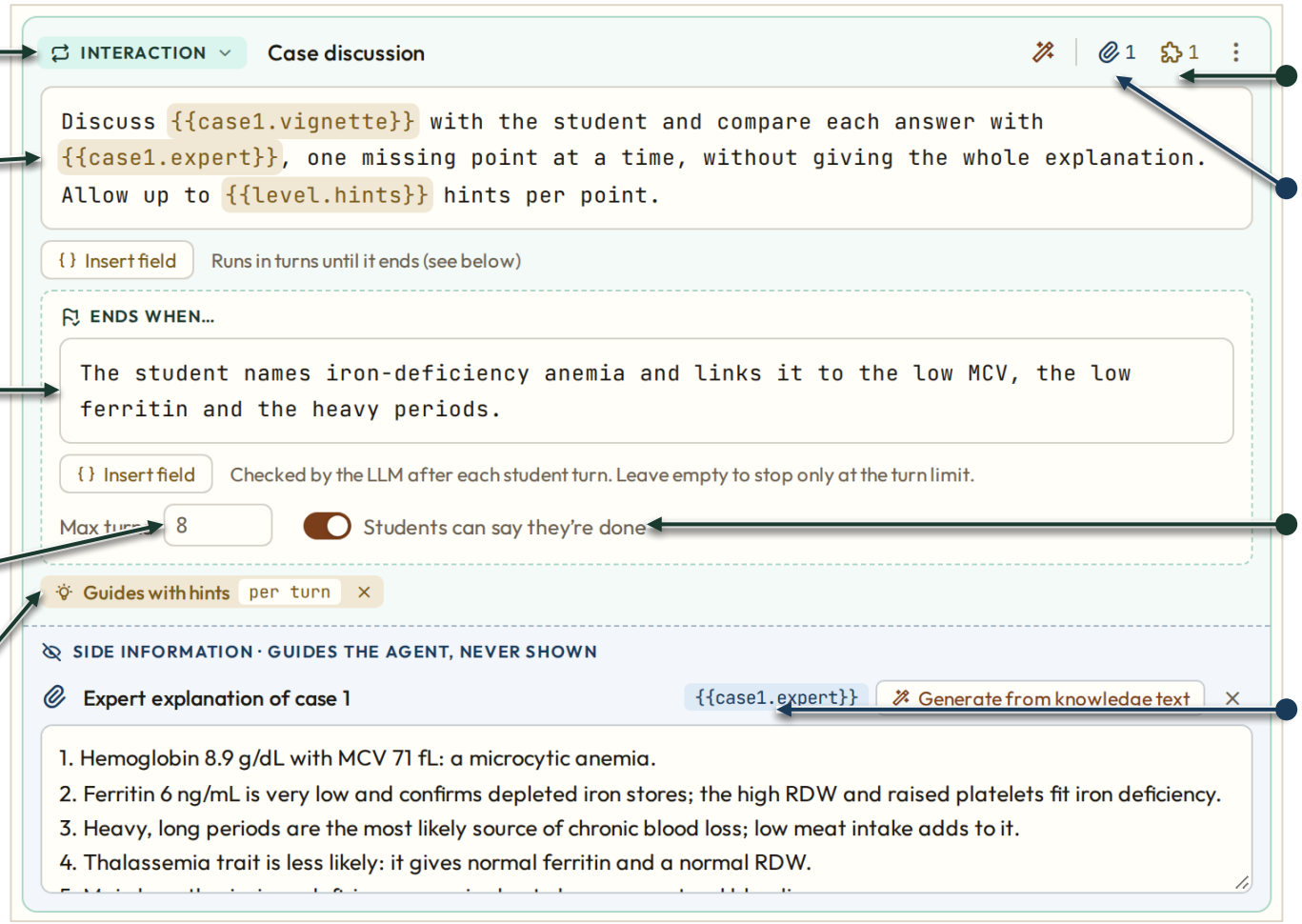
`kind`
interaction

`text`
The agent's prompt: what to discuss, what to compare, how to help

`endsWhen`
Optional end condition, checked by an LLM after each turn

`maxTurns`
Required, 1–50: hard limit on student turns

`strategy`
Feedback, Patient or Gamification



`strategies`
Pick from the popover

`sideInfo`
Attach hidden information

`allowStudentExit`
Shows an I'm done button (on by default)

`expert explanation`
{{case1.expert}}: the hidden evaluator's checklist

How an interaction runs

What the player does with the interaction's settings

After each student turn

1. **Student replies**
   In the chat, or presses I'm done
2. **Hidden evaluator**
   Compares the answers with the expert explanation; the tutor sees what is covered or missing
3. **Turn limit**
   Stops when maxTurns is reached
4. **Ends when…**
   An LLM checks the author's end condition
5. **Agent replies**
   Then back to 1, until the interaction ends

Who opens

The student, if a literal opening question comes just before. Otherwise the agent opens.

Who the agent is

The patient in an interview step, or when a Patient strategy is attached. Otherwise the tutor.

How it ends

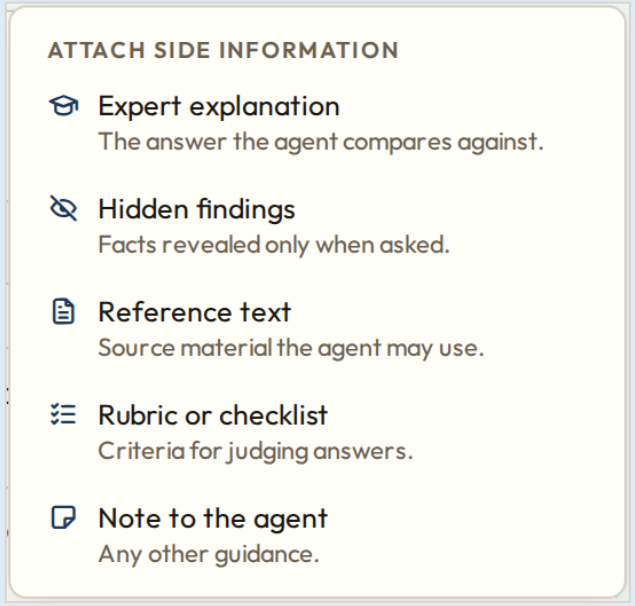
Turn limit, the Ends when… condition, or I'm done. At-end strategies then get one closing turn.

What every element can carry

Side information, fields and strategies connect the pipeline to the agents

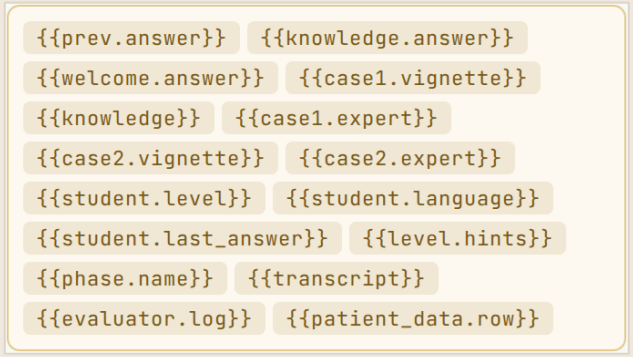
Side information

Hidden text attached to an element. The expert explanation is the evaluator's checklist.



Fields

{{name}} placeholders filled at run time. Never forward: only what exists at that step.



Strategies

Reusable instructions with a moment: on start, per turn or at end.

